

to Daoist sorcery than anything, it is a collection of techniques that must either be taught or sought out through extensive meditation and training. Nei Tan resembles the Daoist concept of the universe, holding the self to be a microcosm of the all, but Hsien invert the process, studying the world to understand the self. This, they hope, may allow them to gain the August Personage's blessing once more. Certainly, mastery of Nei Tan has benefits that would seem to point in that direction — a master of Nei Tan may cross into the Yang World at will, as the Hsien once did — but still the exile remains implacable and resolute. Right thought, even unto enlightenment, is insufficient without right action, and the Shinma struggle to determine just what will allow them to return home.

System: While Nei Tan is based upon the controlled flow of Chi and the intermixing of Yin and Yang, it is not associated with any one Attribute, Skill, or other Trait. Rather, as the practice of Nei Tan relies on balancing one's internal Yin and Yang, the dice pool for any Nei Tan action is the Hsien's Tao score (that being the average of their Chi Attributes) plus one other Trait, which may be an Attribute, Ability, or even a Background — but the Storyteller makes the choice of which Trait, informed by how the player describes what she is attempting to do. There is no one way — there is only The Way.

Should the Hsien's Chi Attributes be out of balance, she will find it quite difficult, if not impossible, to employ the greater reaches of Nei Tan. For every point of difference between her Chi Attributes, one level of Nei Tan is restricted and may not be used, moving down from the fifth level. For example, Shinma with Yin 4 and Yang 2 may only use the first three levels of Nei Tan, even if they have learned the fourth and fifth.

Modifiers work as normal when applied to Nei Tan, though elementally-aspected Fortunes do not.

☉ T'ai Su — The Great Primordial

As Chi condensed into physical form to create the world as we know it, so too do many of the Hsien reverse that effect, gaining total control over the expression of their bodies. At its most basic level, this mimics the capabilities of some mortal monks with extensive training — the Hsien may control her heart rate, her breathing, even her body temperature with fine control. However, because she is a being of pure Chi, her control goes further still, and she may temporarily or even permanently alter her form by will alone.

Shapeshifting: Favored so by tanuki for its usefulness in perpetuating practical jokes that it has entered mortal folklore as a natural capability of theirs, many other Shinma value the technique of Shapeshifting as well. Altering one's features (such as hair, eye, or skin color, sex, and so forth) costs a single die. Unlike other effects, this can be made permanent with the expenditure of 10 dice on the Continuance modifier — fortune (and Fortunes!) must indeed align, but it can be done. To make greater changes, such as transforming into a tree, stone, or other inanimate object, three dice are necessary. To the touch, the Hsien has the properties of whatever she's become, but if struck a Hsien-turned-stone will give way easily, and the transformation will almost certainly fail — a Willpower roll,

difficulty 8, is necessary to maintain the form. Transformation into another species is quite difficult, requiring five dice, and while she may indeed be able to breathe water as a fish or fly as a bird, she does not necessarily understand intuitively how to do so. Additionally, Attributes remain the same, so a Hsien who transforms into an enormous, angry bear does not become the vicious combat powerhouse she might hope to be. Unless she amplifies her Attributes with Wu Tan, she will certainly be weaker than the average bear.

Visage of the Dead: Apart from appearing as living or natural things, the Hsien may tap into the deepest point of Yin she possesses, taking on not only the appearance but the nature of a corpse as well. For so long as she wishes the effect to function, she is dead, wholly and utterly. She does not and cannot perceive what is going on around her; her innermost self is ensconced in a pit of Yin Chi like Yang waiting to boil forth. If her body is disturbed, harmed, or even destroyed in the intervening period, she experiences the effects as soon as the effect ends, which may well kill her in truth.

☉☉ T'ai I — The Great Change

Echoing the birth of reality itself, understanding of this level of Nei Tan allows the Hsien to reinterpret their relationship with the world around them, and so reinterpret themselves, as the Shinma seek a timeless place from which to perceive the 10,000 Things.

The Axis of Time: The Hsien stands astride time itself, following right action through to her goal. The time necessary for any extended action is reduced by half for each die allocated, to a minimum of one turn.

The Timeless Vigil: By stepping outside of time entirely, Shinma may, in effect, enter a state of hibernation, as time passes around them. This is most often used with a Shapeshifting effect to render the Hsien an uninteresting inanimate object, the better to avoid attention. Any active effects placed on the Hsien when she enters this state are suspended — regardless of their Continuance value, they do not terminate until after the The Timeless Vigil runs its course. To the Shinma, time passes in the blink of an eye, though Heaven does not suffer goldbricks well, and sleeping away the ages is a poor use of one's enlightenment.

☉☉☉ T'ai Chi — The Great Pole

To perceive the locus of reality itself is to stand at the axis of the 10,000 Things. They are a lever placed at the perfect fulcrum point, and thus may move the world, which is to say, move the Chi that makes up the world. Yin and Yang are meaningless to the Hsien who achieves this level of enlightenment, or rather, they are one and the same, and she may exchange them freely.

Transmute Chi Values: The Hsien may shift her own internal Chi, exchanging Yin for Yang or Yang for Yin on a one-for-one basis, requiring one die allocated for each. While most practitioners of Nei Tan use this to maintain balance as best they can, some few intentionally throw off that balance, using it to shift Legacies in a heartbeat without meditation. Altered Chi flows persist for a scene, unless one Chi value is